

Top 12 Breaking Balls in the 2027 Draft

If fastballs provide the foundation of the 2027 pitching class, much like many of the arms in the class, breaking balls deepen its identity.

Throughout the evaluation process, one theme appeared again and again: the best pitch in a profile was often a breaking ball. While several pitchers feature elite fastballs, an even larger group derives much of its value from sliders, curveballs, sweepers, and cutters capable of generating professional-level swing-and-miss. In many cases, those breaking balls are not simply complementary offerings. They are the engines that drive the entire profile.

Across the 53 pitchers evaluated for this project, no class characteristic stood out more than the depth of quality spin. Power sliders in the upper-80s, curveballs with exceptional depth, sweepers capable of creating difficult contact points, and cutters thrown with the velocity of traditional fastballs all appeared throughout the database. More importantly, these pitches consistently generated results. They missed bats, stole strikes, expanded the zone, and allowed pitchers to attack hitters in dramatically different ways.

Not all great breaking balls are created equal. Some overwhelm hitters with velocity. Others rely on movement, deception, and shape. Some are designed to generate chase beneath the zone, while others function as strike-stealing weapons early in counts. The pitches ranked below succeeded for different reasons, but all shared one common trait: they project as above-average or better professional offerings and consistently separated themselves from the rest of the class.

These are the twelve best breaking balls in the 2027 college pitching class.

Number 12: Lazaro Collera, RHP, Miami, Sweeper (60)

Metrics: 80.7 | -5.5 IVB | -13.0 HB | -9.25 VAA | 30.5 AA | 2340 RPM

Key Trait: The best true sweeper in the class, combining exceptional depth with significant glove-side movement.

Collera's sweeper earns its place on this list because it does something very few sweepers are capable of doing: it pairs substantial lateral movement with legitimate depth. Many sweepers sacrifice vertical movement in exchange for horizontal break, creating a pitch that moves sideways but remains relatively easy to track. Collera's version avoids that trap. The pitch combines heavy glove-side movement with a steep approach into the zone, creating a breaking ball that consistently moves away from barrels while still finishing beneath them. The results support the shape. The sweeper generated a 35% whiff rate, a 34.9% CSW, and allowed just a .167 batting average during the 2026 season. Most of the swing-and-miss came down and glove side, exactly where a pitch with this movement profile should be living.

What makes the pitch particularly impressive is the velocity band. Sweeping breaking balls often lose effectiveness as velocity increases because maintaining movement becomes more difficult. Collera routinely operated in the low-80s and reached 84.4 mph while preserving both the sweep and depth characteristics that make the pitch effective. Additional velocity could elevate the offering even further and push it into truly elite territory.

The pitch also demonstrated utility against left-handed hitters. While many sweepers struggle against opposite-sided hitters, Collera showed the ability to backdoor the offering and use the depth to keep it competitive in the strike zone. The result was a .200 batting average allowed against left-handed hitters, giving the pitch value against both handedness groups.

Why #12: Collera's sweeper is the only true sweeper to make this list, and it earns that distinction because of its rare combination of movement traits. The pitches ranked above it either generate more swing-and-miss or project slightly better professionally, but few breaking balls in the class match the unusual combination of sweep, depth, and velocity found here.

Number 11: Sam Cozart, RHP, Texas, Slider (60)

Metrics: 85.5 | 3.3 IVB | -4.0 HB | -7.59 VAA | 35.0 AA | 2380 RPM

Key Trait: Premier velocity for a gyro slider allows the pitch to function as both a swing-and-miss weapon and a strike-stealing offering.

Cozart's slider stands out because it refuses to fit neatly into a traditional breaking-ball bucket. Texas labels the pitch as a cutter, and that designation makes sense when watching how he uses it. Unlike many modern sliders that are designed almost exclusively for chase beneath the strike zone, Cozart is comfortable throwing this pitch in virtually any count and to multiple locations. The confidence shows up in both the usage patterns and the command.

The pitch is best described as a power gyro slider. Sitting in the mid-to-upper 80s and reaching 89 mph, it showcases impressive depth despite operating in a velocity band where many breaking balls begin to flatten out. The relatively modest horizontal movement is not a flaw. Instead, it allows the pitch to stay on a direct path toward the hitter before creating late downward action, making it difficult to identify and adjust to in real time.

What separates the offering from many college sliders is its versatility. Cozart consistently lands the pitch glove side and has shown a willingness to elevate it in situations where most pitchers would automatically bury it. That gives the pitch unusual flexibility, allowing it to generate both called strikes and chase. The command profile resembles a cutter more than a traditional wipeout slider, and that ability to steal strikes early in counts enhances the value of the pitch considerably.

The pairing with the fastball is what allows the slider to truly thrive. Hitters are forced to respect one of the better fastballs in the class, creating opportunities for the slider to tunnel effectively before breaking away late. The result was a 45.5% chase rate during the 2026 season, demonstrating how often hitters committed to swings they ultimately could not complete.

Why #11: Cozart's slider may not possess the sweeping movement or eye-popping shape of some pitches ranked above it, but the combination of velocity, command, and versatility gives it genuine professional utility. It can generate swing-and-miss, steal strikes, and pair seamlessly with one of the best fastballs in the class, making it one of the more complete breaking balls on the board.

Number 10: Will Sanford, RHP, Oregon, Curveball (60)

Metrics: 76.3 | -18.5 IVB | -9.7 HB | -10.11 VAA | 32.9 AA | 2790 RPM

Key Trait: Elite depth paired with uncommon strike-throwing ability creates one of the most traditional curveballs in the class.

Sanford's curveball is the centerpiece of his secondary arsenal and one of the best examples of a classic curveball in college baseball. Thrown in the mid-70s with nearly 18.5 inches of depth and spin rates approaching 2,800 RPM, the pitch combines elite shape with unusually advanced feel. The result is a breaking ball that consistently earns strikes without needing hitters to chase it.

The most impressive aspect of the pitch is its ability to generate called strikes. Despite producing only an 11% swinging-strike rate, the curve generated a 37% CSW because hitters frequently froze against its combination of depth, velocity separation, and late movement. Sanford consistently showed the confidence to land the pitch in the strike zone, and that willingness to challenge hitters prevents opponents from simply taking it out of hand.

The shape itself is exceptional. The curve creates a nearly 40-inch movement differential and 17 mph velocity separation from Sanford's fastball, giving hitters an entirely different movement plane to account for. The pitch arrives on such a steep trajectory that its approach into the zone resembles what many curveballs look like when finishing beneath it. That late depth routinely forces hitters into poor swing decisions and uncomfortable contact.

Even when hitters manage to put the pitch in play, they rarely do damage. Sanford's curveball allowed a batting average below .250, did not surrender an extra-base hit, and generated ground balls at a 72% clip. With two strikes, the pitch became even more effective. When located down and glove side, the curve finished at-bats with a remarkable 58% out-of-zone whiff rate, demonstrating its ability to function as both a strike-stealing offering and a legitimate put-away pitch.

Why #10: Sanford's curveball may not possess the overwhelming swing-and-miss numbers of some of the pitches ranked above it, but its combination of shape, spin, command, and strike-getting ability creates one of the most complete breaking balls in the 2027 class. Few pitchers demonstrate this level of confidence throwing a curveball for both strikes and outs.

Number 9: Jackson Barberi, RHP, Florida, Slider (60)

Metrics: 85.3 | -0.8 IVB | -7.2 HB | -8.14 VAA | 40.1 AA | 2640 RPM

Key Trait: High-spin, two-plane shape with exceptional depth creates a professional out pitch against hitters from both sides of the plate.

Barberi's slider earns its place on this list because of the quality of the pitch itself rather than simply its relationship with the fastball. Operating in the mid-80s with over 2,600 RPM of spin, the offering combines above-average glove-side movement with sharp, late depth that allows it to miss bats in multiple ways. The shape is powerful enough to generate swing-and-miss both within the strike zone and beneath it, giving Barberi a true put-away weapon.

The pitch generated a 38.3% whiff rate during the 2026 season and showed utility against both handedness groups. Against right-handed hitters, Barberi consistently worked the slider down and away, creating chase opportunities and finishing at-bats. Against left-handed hitters, he demonstrated the ability to both backdoor the pitch for called strikes and backfoot it beneath barrels. That location versatility significantly expands the pitch's usefulness and prevents hitters from anticipating a single movement pattern or target.

A major reason for the pitch's effectiveness is the depth created through its spin profile. The slider enters the zone on an exceptionally steep -8.14° VAA, allowing it to maintain its downward action deep into flight. Rather than relying solely on sweep or velocity, Barberi generates a shape that consistently forces hitters to swing over the top of the baseball. The result is a breaking ball that functions equally well as a chase pitch and a strike-getter.

The pitch's ability to create outs independent of count, location, or handedness is what elevates it into this tier. While the fastball certainly enhances the overall profile, the slider already possesses the tools necessary to project as a professional out pitch on its own merits.

Why #9: Barberi's slider combines velocity, spin, depth, and location versatility into one of the more complete breaking balls in the class. The pitches ranked above it generate either more extreme movement profiles or greater overall impact, but few breaking balls offer a more balanced combination of present effectiveness and professional projection.

Number 8: Rhys Bowie, LHP, Wake Forest, Cutter (60)

Metrics: 90.8 | 2.7 IVB | 3.1 HB | -5.87 VAA | 20.1 AA | 2780 RPM

Key Trait: Elite velocity and exceptional gyro characteristics allow the pitch to generate both chase and swing-and-miss while attacking multiple quadrants of the strike zone.

Bowie's cutter is one of the most unusual pitches in the class. While officially classified as a cutter, the offering often behaves more like a power gyro slider, combining exceptional firmness with late glove-side movement and consistent depth. Sitting over 90 mph, very few collegiate breaking balls operate in the same velocity band while maintaining this level of shape integrity.

The pitch's effectiveness stems from its versatility. Bowie consistently demonstrated the ability to backdoor the pitch to right-handed hitters, land it down and in against righties, and crowd left-handed hitters underneath their hands. Unlike many cutters that primarily function as contact-management offerings, Bowie's version is fully capable of missing bats while remaining in the strike zone.

The underlying results were exceptional. The pitch generated a 40.4% whiff rate and 16.6% swinging-strike rate, numbers more commonly associated with premier sliders than traditional cutters. The combination of velocity, late movement, and a steep finishing angle frequently forces hitters to commit before they fully recognize the shape, creating uncomfortable swings and poor-quality contact.

The pitch also benefits from its ability to complement the rest of Bowie's arsenal. Hitters must respect elite velocity from both his four-seam fastball and sinker, allowing the cutter to arrive from a familiar release window before taking a dramatically different path. Even when hitters anticipate the pitch, the combination of velocity and late movement makes consistent contact difficult.

Why #8: Bowie's cutter is the best pure cutter in the class. While the pitches ranked above it generate either more extreme movement or greater overall impact, few breaking balls combine velocity, versatility, and swing-and-miss ability as effectively as this one. It is a true professional weapon and one of the most unique offerings in the 2027 class.

Number 7: Zach Edwards, RHP, Oregon State, Slider (60)

Metrics: 85.1 | 6.3 IVB | -10.6 HB | -7.76 VAA | 58.0 AA | 2280 RPM

Key Trait: Lifted slider shape paired with exceptional command beneath the strike zone creates one of the premier put-away pitches in the class.

Edwards' slider is the carrying pitch in the arsenal and one of the most effective bat-missing breaking balls in the class. Thrown in the mid-80s with significant glove-side movement and unusual lift for a pitch in this velocity band, the slider consistently creates uncomfortable swing decisions while maintaining enough shape diversity to separate itself from more traditional gyro profiles.

What makes the pitch stand out is not simply the movement profile, but how well Edwards commands it. Rather than relying on hitters to chase a pitch that starts well off the plate, he routinely lands the slider just beneath the strike zone where hitters are forced to make a decision. The pitch spends enough time looking competitive before finishing underneath barrels, creating one of the most consistent swing-and-miss weapons in the class. The ability to repeatedly locate the pitch in that zone separates it from many similarly shaped breaking balls.

The results were exceptional. Edwards generated a 60.5% whiff rate and 27.1% swinging-strike rate, numbers that place the pitch among the best breaking balls in the entire database. Those results were not confined to a single handedness group, either. The slider generated chase from both right-handed and left-handed hitters, giving Edwards a reliable finishing pitch regardless of matchup.

The shape itself is somewhat unconventional. While many high-end sliders win through steep downward movement or extreme sweep, Edwards' version carries more lift than most pitchers would intentionally design. Rather than harming the pitch, that characteristic helps it remain visually competitive longer and enhances its ability to generate swings beneath the baseball. Combined with plus command and mid-80s velocity, the result is a breaking ball capable of missing bats at every level.

Why #7: Few pitches in the class can match the raw swing-and-miss production of Edwards' slider. The pitches ranked above it offer greater shape quality, broader professional utility, or more complete movement profiles, but Edwards possesses one of the premier put-away breaking balls in college baseball and a pitch that already projects comfortably as a professional out pitch.

Number 6: William Schmidt, RHP, LSU, Slider (60)

Metrics: 85.5 | -0.4 IVB | -1.8 HB | -8.44 VAA | 50.2 AA | 2660 RPM

Key Trait: A high-velocity gyro slider with elite depth creates one of the steepest and most difficult-to-track breaking balls in the class.

Schmidt's slider is the defining pitch of his arsenal and one of the purest examples of a power gyro breaking ball in the 2027 class. Operating comfortably in the mid-to-upper 80s, the pitch combines exceptional velocity with plus depth, creating a steep movement profile that consistently finishes underneath barrels. Unlike many modern sliders that rely primarily on sweep, Schmidt's version wins through late vertical action and raw power.

What makes the pitch especially dangerous is how difficult it is to recognize. The tight gyro spin limits visible movement early in flight, allowing the pitch to stay on a fastball-like trajectory before abruptly disappearing beneath contact points. That late finish produced a 52% whiff rate, a 22% swinging-strike rate, and 119 total whiffs during the 2026 season, placing it among the most productive breaking balls in the class.

The pitch also serves as Schmidt's primary finishing weapon. He consistently works it down and glove side, using the depth to generate chase beneath the strike zone while maintaining enough command to land it competitively when necessary. The result was a 31% put-away rate, highlighting both the quality of the shape and Schmidt's ability to deploy it in leverage situations.

There is still room for refinement. The pitch will occasionally back up or remain elevated, though even those mistakes frequently result in called strikes rather than damaging contact because hitters remain conscious of the depth it typically produces. Continued improvement executing the backdoor version against left-handed hitters would add another layer to an already impressive offering.

Why #6: Schmidt's slider possesses some of the best perceived depth in the class and combines it with uncommon velocity for a breaking ball. The pitches ranked ahead of it either offer more movement diversity or greater overall impact, but few breaking balls can match the combination of power, steepness, and swing-and-miss ability found here.

Number 5: Sean Jenkins, RHP, ECU, Slider (60)

Metrics: 88.4 | 1.9 IVB | -3.7 HB | -7.04 VAA | 52.3 AA | 2560 RPM

Key Trait: Elite velocity paired with above-average glove-side movement creates one of the hardest to hit gyro sliders in the class.

Jenkins' slider is the defining pitch in the arsenal and one of the most physically impressive breaking balls in the 2027 class. Thrown at 88-89 mph and touching 92, the pitch operates in a velocity band rarely seen among collegiate sliders while still maintaining enough movement to consistently miss bats. Rather than relying on massive sweep, the offering succeeds with late depth, tight spin, and exceptional power.

What separates the pitch from many other hard sliders is its command. Jenkins consistently located it down and glove side against right-handed hitters, where it served as the primary put-away weapon. Against left-handed hitters, he showed the confidence to both bury the pitch beneath the zone and backdoor it for strikes, giving the offering utility against either handedness. While the occasional backup slider or middle miss happens, the overall command profile is above average.

The pitch also generates far more than swing-and-miss. Despite functioning as a power breaking ball, it managed contact exceptionally well throughout the season. Jenkins actually generated more ground balls with the slider than with his sinker, while allowing a miniscule 83.4 mph average exit velocity. Hitters routinely found themselves in between swing decisions, producing either empty swings or weak contact on the ground.

The combination of velocity and movement makes the pitch particularly difficult to prepare for. Many hitters simply do not see breaking balls in this velocity band on a regular basis, and the late depth gives them very little time to adjust once they recognize the shape. When paired with Jenkins' power sinker, it becomes one of the most difficult pitch combinations in the class to handle.

Why #5: Jenkins possesses one of the hardest breaking balls in the country, but the slider earns this ranking because it combines velocity with command and contact management. The pitches ranked above it offer more complete overall shape profiles, but few breaking balls in the 2027 class can match the combination of power, effectiveness, and professional impact potential found here.

Number 4: Chris Levonas, RHP, Wake Forest, Slider (65)

Metrics: 84.6 | 1.2 IVB | -13.5 HB | -7.69 VAA | 43.2 AA | 2630 RPM

Key Trait: Heavy sweep paired with above-average velocity and elite spin creates a late-breaking slider that generates both whiffs and uncomfortable takes.

Levonas' slider is the premier weapon in his arsenal and one of the best pure strikeout pitches in the 2027 class. Thrown in the mid-80s with substantial glove-side movement, the pitch combines the sweep associated with a modern bat-missing slider while maintaining enough velocity to prevent hitters from comfortably recognizing and adjusting to it. The shape consistently stays on plane before breaking sharply late, allowing the pitch to generate swings both in and out of the strike zone.

The results are elite. Levonas generated a 52%+ whiff rate, produced a 25%+ swinging-strike rate, and turned nearly half of his two-strike sliders into strikeouts. Very few breaking balls in the class can match that combination of volume and effectiveness. The pitch repeatedly finished at-bats without requiring hitters to chase dramatically out of the zone, a strong indicator that the shape itself is driving the success. What stands out most is the consistency. The whiff locations are concentrated almost entirely in ideal chase areas beneath and just off the glove-side edge of the zone. Levonas repeatedly lands the pitch in the same window, allowing the movement profile to do the work. Unlike many collegiate sliders that flash quality shape but lack reliable execution, this pitch consistently arrives where it is intended.

The slider also carries true starter utility. Levonas shows no hesitation throwing it to hitters from either side of the plate and is comfortable using it in virtually any count. Whether he needs a chase pitch with two strikes or a breaking ball for a called strike early in the at-bat, the slider remains effective. That flexibility separates it from many breaking balls that function primarily as platoon-specific weapons.

Why #4: Levonas combines elite swing-and-miss ability, starter utility, command, and shape into one package. The pitches ranked above it either possess even more exceptional movement characteristics or slightly greater overall impact, but few breaking balls in the class are as complete or as consistently effective as Levonas' slider.

Number 3: Dax Whitney, RHP, Oregon State, Slider (65)

Metrics: 85.6 | -2.2 IVB | -13.4 HB | -8.49 VAA | 51.6 AA | 2710 RPM

Key Trait: Rare combination of sweep, depth, and velocity allows the pitch to miss bats in any count and against either handedness.

Whitney's slider is the best professional breaking ball in the class not named Rhys Bowie's curveball. Thrown in the mid-80s with over 13 inches of glove-side movement and nearly 2,700 RPM of spin, the pitch combines virtually every trait evaluators look for in a modern bat-missing breaking ball. It possesses the sweep of a sweeper, the depth of a slider, the velocity of a power breaker, and the spin characteristics to maintain all of those traits deep into flight.

What separates Whitney's slider from most breaking balls is that there are very few weaknesses in the profile. Many elite sliders rely heavily on one characteristic, whether that be velocity, sweep, or depth. Whitney's offering checks every box. The movement profile is substantial without becoming loopy, the velocity keeps hitters from recognizing it early, and the steep approach angle allows the pitch to finish beneath barrels consistently. The results fully support the shape. Whitney generated a 56.8% whiff rate, 24.4% swinging-strike rate, and 51.7% CSW, placing the pitch among the most dominant offerings in the database. The slider served as his primary finishing weapon against right-handed hitters, but it also showed enough shape and command diversity to create problems for left-handed hitters. Unlike many breaking balls that rely on chase beneath the zone, Whitney's slider can generate empty swings both inside and outside the strike zone.

The pitch also benefits from one of the premier fastballs in the class, but it does not depend on it. The shape is strong enough to generate its own outcomes independent of sequencing, which is one of the clearest indicators of an elite professional breaking ball. Whether thrown for a strike early, buried beneath the zone with two strikes, or back-footed against opposite-handed hitters, the pitch consistently produces uncomfortable swings and weak contact.

Why #3: Whitney's slider combines elite results, premium velocity, substantial sweep, quality depth, and plus spin into one complete package. Only two breaking balls in the class offer a stronger overall combination of shape, effectiveness, and professional projection.

Number 2: Dylan Volantis, LHP, Texas, Curveball (65)

Metrics: 81.3 | -11.3 IVB | 3.2 HB | -10.11 VAA | 40.4 AA | 2540 RPM

Key Trait: A true deathball shape paired with a unique release and advanced command allows the pitch to generate both strikes and whiffs at an elite rate.

Volantis' curveball is the defining pitch of his arsenal and one of the few breaking balls in the class capable of carrying an entire profile on its own. Thrown in the low-80s with exceptional depth, the pitch features a rare deathball shape that enters the zone on an extremely steep plane before disappearing beneath barrels. What makes the offering particularly uncomfortable is the release profile. Volantis delivers the pitch from an unusually high slot, creating a visual look that hitters rarely encounter and making the vertical break appear even more dramatic.

The pitch accounted for the overwhelming majority of his swing-and-miss production during the 2026 season, generating more than 100 whiffs against right-handed hitters alone. Unlike many elite breaking balls that operate almost exclusively as chase pitches, Volantis demonstrates the ability to use the curveball at every stage of an at-bat. He can land it early for strikes and bury it beneath the zone when searching for a punchout. That flexibility dramatically increases the value of the pitch and allows it to function as more than a traditional out pitch. The command is what separates the curveball from other high-spin breaking balls. Volantis consistently places the pitch in ideal locations and rarely wastes it. Hitters struggle to make quality swing decisions because of the combination of late depth, unusual angle, and precise location. The pitch routinely freezes hitters for called strikes while also generating empty swings beneath the zone, a balance few breaking balls are able to maintain.

Even among the elite offerings in this article, this curveball feels unique. Volantis wins almost entirely through vertical movement, shape, and command. The result is a pitch that already projects as a legitimate professional out pitch and one that should remain effective against advanced hitters.

Why #2: Volantis possesses one of the most complete breaking balls in the class. The shape is elite, the command is advanced, and the results speak for themselves. Only one pitch in the 2027 class combines raw movement, swing-and-miss ability, and professional projection more effectively.

Number 1: Rhys Bowie, LHP, Wake Forest, Curveball (70)

Metrics: 82.1 | -14.4 IVB | 13.3 HB | -8.81 VAA | 21.4 AA | 2770 RPM

Key Trait: A rare combination of low-release deception, plus depth, plus sweep, and premium velocity creates the most complete breaking ball in the class.

Bowie's curveball stands alone atop this list because it combines elite traits in a way very few breaking balls can. Thrown at over 82 mph with nearly 2,800 RPM of spin, the pitch already possesses the velocity and spin characteristics associated with premier professional breaking balls. Pair that with over 14 inches of depth and more than 13 inches of glove-side movement, and the result is a pitch that attacks hitters from multiple directions simultaneously.

What truly separates the curveball, however, is the release profile. Most breaking balls thrown from lower release heights tend to sacrifice depth in favor of horizontal movement, creating sweep-heavy shapes that move across the plate but do not consistently finish beneath barrels. Bowie's curveball does the opposite. Despite coming from a relatively low release point, it still generates true power-curveball depth while maintaining plus sweep. The result is a pitch that creates an incredibly uncomfortable visual for hitters, appearing to move in one direction before sharply disappearing in another.

The pitch's movement and release profile is matched by its production. Opposing hitters swung and missed at a 58% rate while producing a 22% swinging-strike rate, numbers that place the pitch among the most dominant offerings in college baseball. Even when hitters managed to put the pitch in play, they struggled to do damage, batting just .174 against it during the 2026 season. The command further elevates the pitch. Bowie consistently located the curveball at the bottom of the strike zone and just beneath it, allowing the shape to work at maximum effectiveness. He showed the ability to throw it for strikes early in counts and expand it beneath the zone with two strikes, giving the offering utility throughout the entirety of an at-bat rather than simply functioning as a chase pitch.

Unlike many elite breaking balls that derive their value from a single standout characteristic, Bowie's curveball excels across every major category. The velocity is elite. The spin is elite. The depth is plus. The sweep is plus. The command is plus. There simply are not many weaknesses to identify.

Why #1: No breaking ball in the 2027 class combines velocity, spin, depth, sweep, command, and production as completely as Bowie's curveball. It is a true double-plus offering, a legitimate professional out pitch today, and the best breaking ball in the 2027 college pitching class.